

What Makes Political Authority Trustworthy?

A public-derived measure across politicians, government agencies, trust and distrust

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Trust in trouble?

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ARTICLE

A Crisis of Political Trust? Global Trends in Institutional Trust from 1958 to 2019

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Data based on 3,377 surveys conducted by 50 projects in 143 countries over the 60 year period (1958–2019), including **89 countries** rating as liberal or electoral democracies for a majority of those years

British Journal of
Political Science

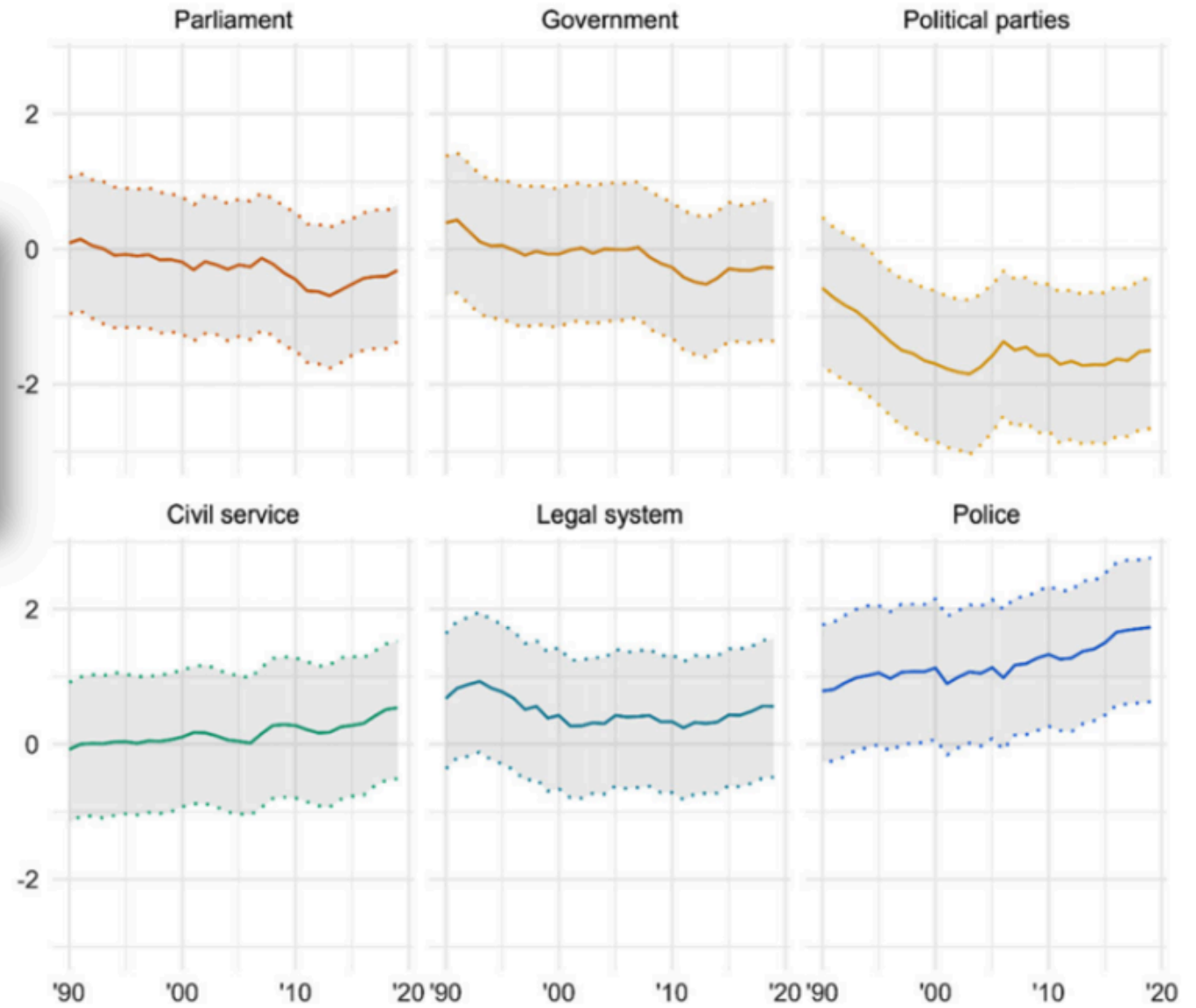


Figure 9. Bayesian estimates for latent global trends in trust in six institutions, from global models using harmonized survey data, including only democracies.

A trust rating records a judgment, not its standard

- The rating alone cannot tell us which standard is doing the work.
- The same rating may reflect a **mix of perceptions and emotions.**
 - competence, honesty, or even just physical attractiveness.
- From our CATI survey (2024):

"The way he looks at you in the eye"
"Because she's a battler and a single mum"

B. TRUST IN INSTITUTIONS

7-17 I'm going to name a number of institutions. For each one, please tell me how much trust do you have in them? (Do not read: Do not understand the question, Can't choose & Decline to answer)

(SHOWCARD)	A Great Deal of Trust	Quite a Lot of Trust	Not Very Much Trust	None At All	Do not understand the question	Can't Choose	Decline to answer
7. The president (for presidential system) or Prime Minister (for parliamentary system)	1	2	3	4	7	8	9
8. The courts	1	2	3	4	7	8	9
9. The national government [in capital city]	1	2	3	4	7	8	9
10. Political parties [not any specific party]	1	2	3	4	7	8	9
11. Parliament	1	2	3	4	7	8	9
12. Civil service	1	2	3	4	7	8	9
13. The military or armed forces	1	2	3	4	7	8	9
14. The police	1	2	3	4	7	8	9
15. Local government	1	2	3	4	7	8	9
16. The election commission [specify institution by name] <Optional>	1	2	3	4	7	8	9

Trustworthiness links **standards to the decision to trust**; political trustworthiness is the **perceived quality** of a political object that makes confidence more or less warranted.

Dimensions (and drivers) of trust / trustworthiness in existing research

Study		Mayer et al 1995	Hetherington & Rudolph 2008	OECD 2017 ,2025			World Values Survey 2017-2021 (Wave 7)		Grimmelikhuijsen & Knies 2017	Hamm et al. 2019; Weinberg 2023	Devine et al 2024	Seyd 2024		
Focus/ context		Organisational trust (internal)	Political trust	Public trust in institutions			Political trust (Parlt, Govt, UN)	Norris 2022	Public institutions (external)	Political trust	Govt (political institutional)	Trust in politicians		
Survey question dimensions / constructs used	1	Ability	Performance	Competence		Values	Competence & efficiency	Competence & efficiency	Competence		Ability	Competence	Competence	
	2	Benevolence	Process		Responsiveness			Duty execution						
	3												Benevolence	
	4							Motivation		Benevolence	Integrity	Benevolence	Benevolence	
	5							Openness and transparency					Integrity	Integrity
	6		Intention		Impartiality			Integrity				Integrity		
	7	Integrity			Reliability									
	8				Integrity		Freedom from corruption	Integrity						
	9				Fairness									
	10		Priming											

How we have done in identifying the dimensions (and drivers, or antecedents) of trust for empirical and policy purposes, from the public's point of view:

- **CATI interviews (2024)**: citizens described what makes political authority worthy or unworthy of trust.
 - Candidate battery: those accounts became a broader pool of roughly 20 survey items.
- **ACVS (Australian Constitution Values Survey) Panel Survey W1 (2025)**: the first panel test examined how the item pool worked across trusted and distrusted political objects.
- **ACVS Panel Survey W2 (2026)**: the second panel test helped refine the wording, routing and facet structure.
- **ACVS standalone survey (2026)**: the final design centred on the five-facet, 15-item core and compared it with benchmark models.

Public accounts extend the familiar competence-benevolence-integrity model

Public-derived facet	What respondents are asked to assess	Established CBI content
Performance	competence and the capacity to carry out duties	Competence
Integrity	honesty, acceptable values and absence of hidden motives	Integrity
Promise keeping	doing what was said and remaining accountable	---
Treatment	fairness, respect and listening to citizens	---
Motivation	concern for citizens and willingness to serve	Benevolence

- The measurement question is whether these recurring standards are **independent dimensions or diagnostic facets of a common judgement**.
- The proposed battery retains a recognisable **CBI core while making two politically salient standards** explicit.

Exact wording of the 15-item battery

Shown in politician wording. Agency questions used "they/their" where appropriate.

Item	Facet	Positive statement	Negative statement
1	Performance	[He/She] is competent	[He/She] is incompetent
2	Performance	[He/She] knows what [he/she] is doing	[He/She] doesn't know what [he/she] is doing
3	Performance	[He/She] carries out [his/her] duty well	[He/She] fails to carry out [his/her] duty
4	Integrity	[He/She] is honest	[He/She] is not honest
5	Integrity	[He/She] has no hidden motives	[He/She] has hidden motives
6	Integrity	[He/She] has values I agree with	I disagree with [his/her] values
7	Promise keeping	[He/She] does what [he/she] says [he/she] will do	[He/She] doesn't do what [he/she] says [he/she] will do
8	Promise keeping	[He/She] meets people's needs	[He/She] fails to meet people's needs
9	Promise	[He/She] is held accountable for	[He/She] is not held accountable for

Exact wording of remaining battery and extension items

Items 10-15 complete the 15-item core. Items 16-19 are extensions.

Item	Facet	Positive statement	Negative statement
10	Treatment	[He/She] treats people fairly	[He/She] doesn't treat people fairly
11	Treatment	[He/She] treats people with respect	[He/She] doesn't treat people with respect
12	Treatment	[He/She] listens to people	[He/She] doesn't listen to people
13	Motivation	[He/She] is genuinely interested in the wellbeing of citizens	[He/She] has no genuine interest in the wellbeing of citizens
14	Motivation	[He/She] lets people engage in decisions	[He/She] does not let people engage in decisions
15	Motivation	[He/She] does [his/her] best to help citizens in need	[He/She] does little to help citizens in need
16	Extension:	[He/She] approaches citizens in a sincere	Same wording

The Devine et al. (2024) six-item benchmark as the CBI proxy

The Devine benchmark uses six ACVS counterparts:

- competence: items 1 and 3
- benevolence: items 13 and 19
- integrity: items 17 and 5

All driver items are harmonised so that higher values indicate greater perceived trustworthiness.

Putting the refined battery under a common test

We fielded our **standalone survey (2026)** from 6–30 July 2026 among 3,023 Australian adults.

Three questions guide the test

1. Do **politicians and government agencies** make different trustworthiness criteria more salient? **(RQ1)**
2. Does the **five-facet, 15-item battery** capture trustworthiness judgments better than the benchmark alternatives? **(RQ2)**
3. Do **positive and negative statements** change the difficulty of measuring the same criteria? **(RQ3)**

Putting the refined battery under a common test

Route	n	Pre-selected objects
Politician	1,510	most- or least-trusted nomination: Anthony Albanese (PM), Angus Taylor (Opposition leader), Pauline Hanson (RRP leader)
Government agency	1,513	most- or least-trusted nomination: Australian Taxation Office, state/territory police, state/territory hospital services

- five-point trust rating for the nominated object
- randomised block polarity for the wording experiment
 - [He/She] is competent / [He/She] is incompetent
 - [He/She] does [his/her] best to help citizens in need [He/She] does little to help citizens in need

Results

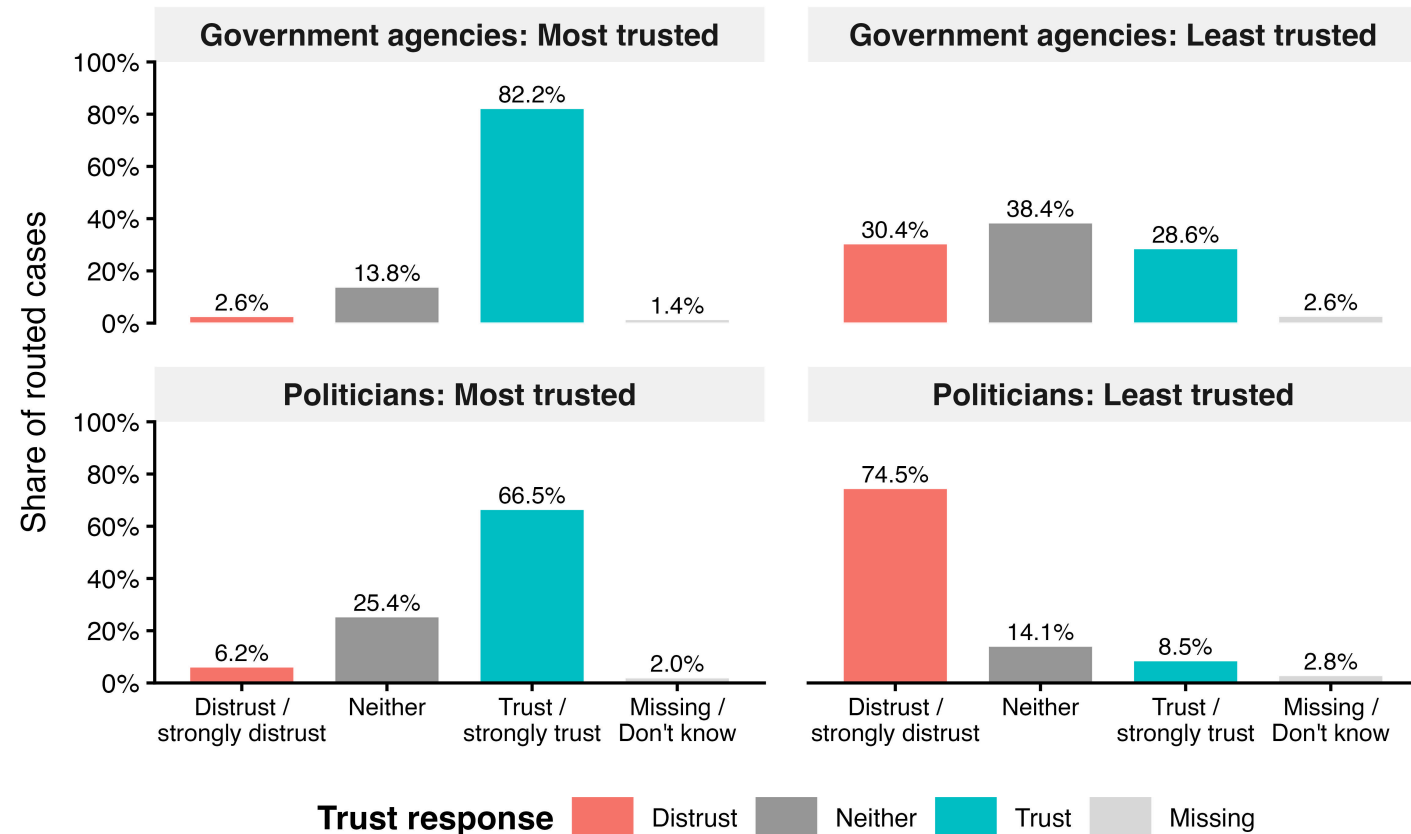
Nomination changes what "least trusted" means (RQ1)

- **74.5%** of least-trusted politician ratings are distrust or strong distrust.
- In contrast, only **30.4%** of least-trusted agency ratings are distrust or strong distrust.

Object type and evaluative position belong within validation...We have more afterwards.

Distribution of trust ratings by nominated object

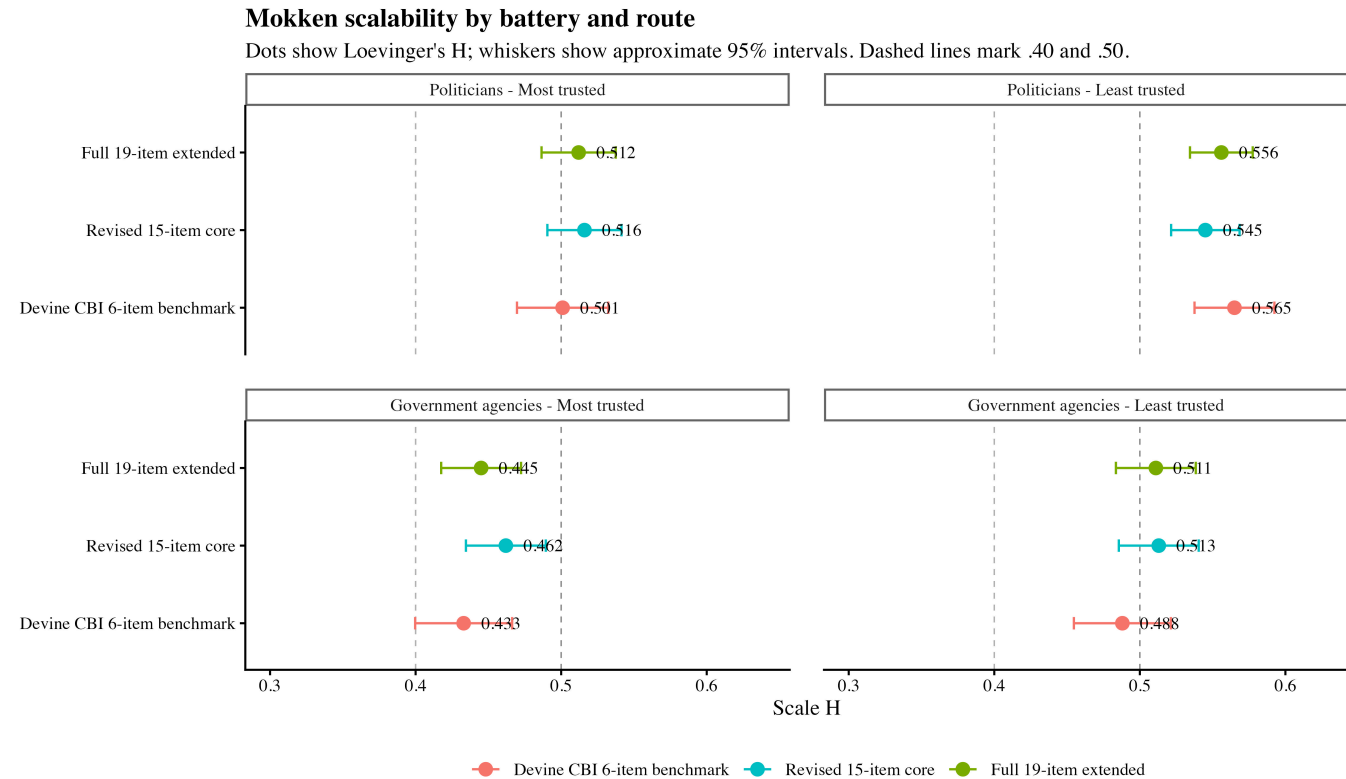
Percentages use all routed cases; labels show every response share



A useful battery has to pass three different checks (RQ2)

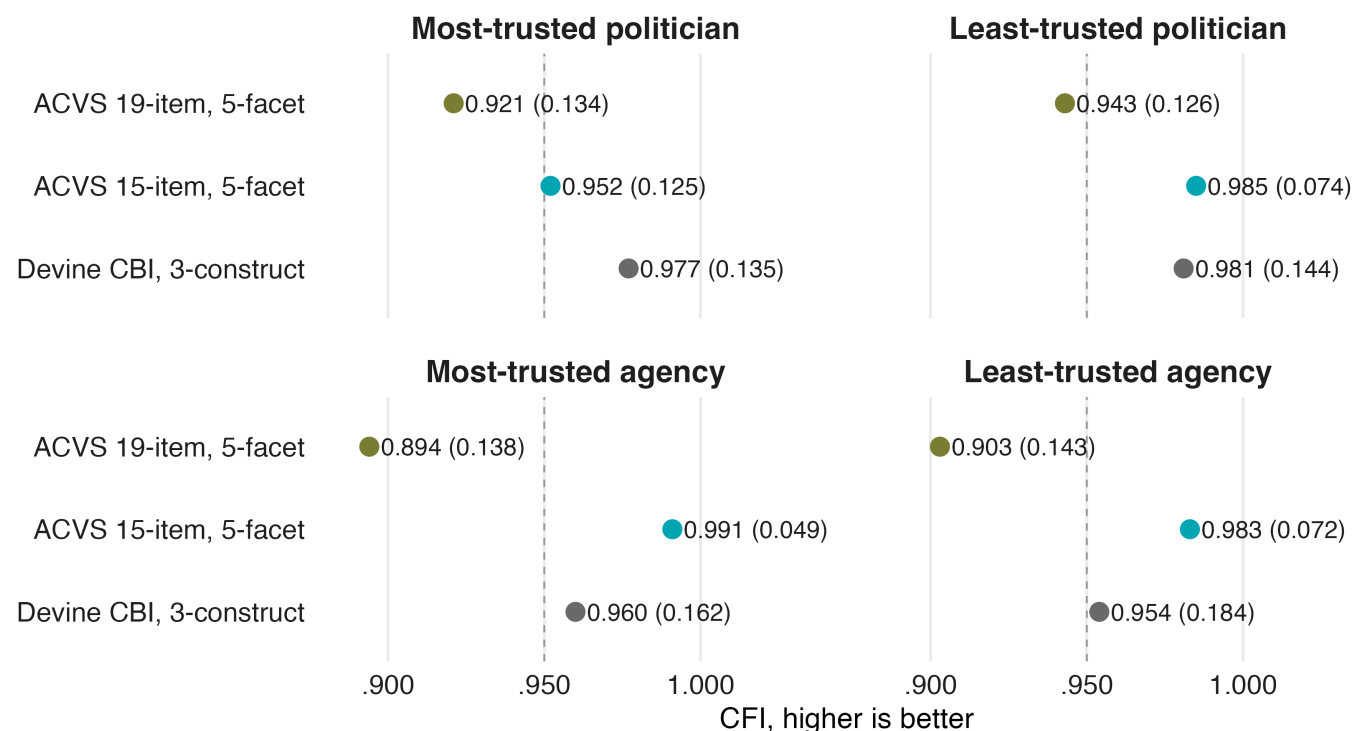
1. **Ordinal coherence:** *Mokken H* tests whether the items form a coherent ordered scale.
2. **Structural improvement:** *CFA* tests whether a facet organisation improves on a single factor.
3. **Interpretive boundary:** *latent correlations* show whether facets are empirically separable (admissibility).

Mokken H tests: All three batteries scale coherently



The 15-item core is highest in three routes, but the differences are modest. The full extension and the Devine benchmark also show monotonic scalability.

Overall, The 15-item five-facet battery has the strongest CFA profile



The public-derived five-facet core is the best-fitting candidate in three routes and remains a strong, politically broader comparator in the most-trusted politician route.

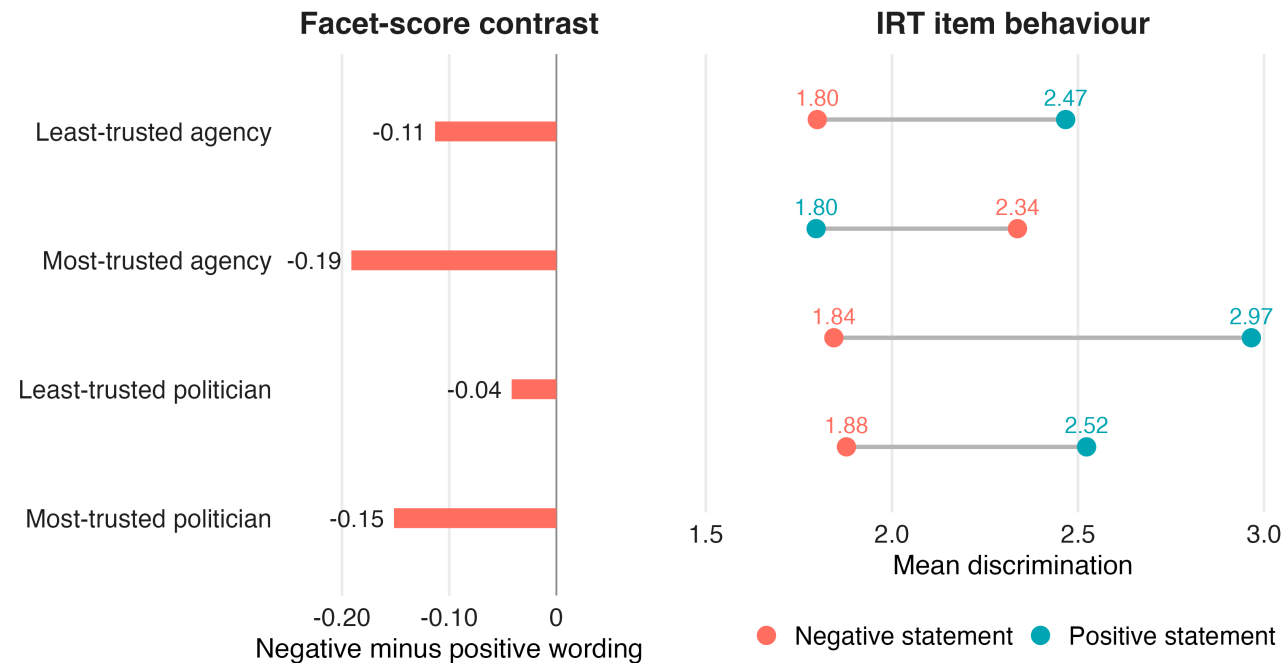
Nonetheless, fit gains do not make the five facets independent

Latent-facet pair	Correlation range across routes
Performance–promise keeping	.953–.992
Integrity–treatment	.948–.984
Motivation–promise keeping	.924–1.031

- The most-trusted politician solution is *inadmissible* because one correlation exceeds 1. The agency solutions are acceptable, yet still close to the boundary of separation. (But all the other solutions perform similarly.)

Therefore, the five facets are best used as diagnostic parts of a general trustworthiness judgement.

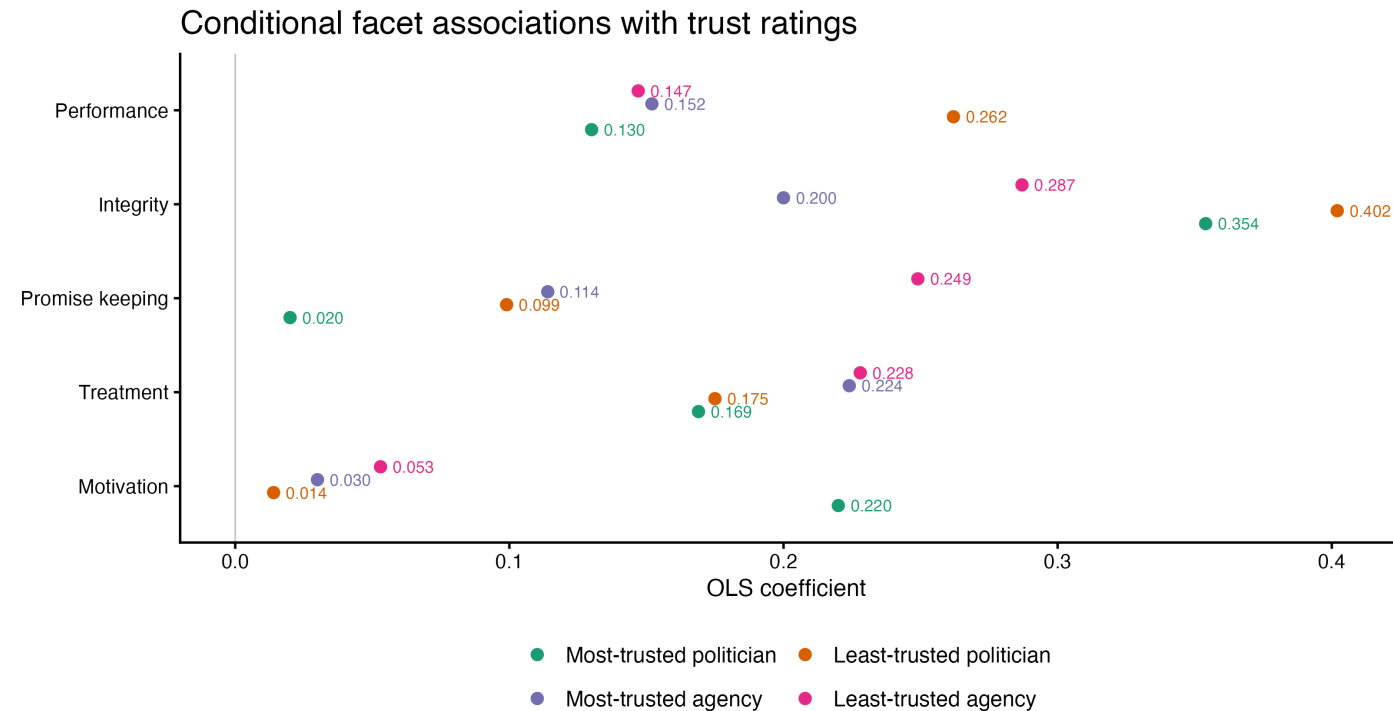
Reverse scoring aligns direction; wording still changes item behaviour (RQ3)



Positive wording usually produces higher harmonised facet scores and sharper average discrimination. Most-trusted agencies are the exception, so polarity is a design issue rather than a universal rule about which wording is better.

The facets connect to trust *differently* across political objects

- Integrity is the strongest association for politicians.
- Treatment is especially prominent for most-trusted agencies. (which is not in the traditional CBI-model)
- Integrity, promise keeping and treatment are all important for least-trusted agencies.



What do we learn about political trustworthiness?

The public-derived battery adds content without discarding CBI

The Devine et al, 2024 CBI benchmark remains a credible compact measure. Our battery adds **promise keeping** and **treatment**, which are visible in public explanations of political trust and distrust but are often compressed into broader constructs.

A structured measure of one judgement

The 15-item core gives the strongest current measure of perceived political trustworthiness.

- It scales coherently across politicians and government agencies.
- It improves the five-facet structure over a single-factor model.
- It keeps promise keeping and treatment visible alongside competence, benevolence and integrity.

Caveats

- Its facets remain highly correlated, so they work best as diagnostic standards within a common judgement.
- Object (which is very context-sensitive), nomination route and wording all affect what the battery reveals.

Bottom line: political trustworthiness can be measured as a broad evaluative judgement with meaningful public-derived facets.

Thanks!

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Find our latest findings:

<https://tinyurl.com/Griffith-Trust>



Mapping and Harnessing Public (Mis)Trust

Evidence Snapshots

Australian Constitutional
Values Survey 2023-2026

